

A vertical crack runs down the center of a dark, textured surface. A bright, glowing orange light emanates from the crack, creating a vertical beam of light that illuminates the surrounding area. The light has a grainy, textured appearance, suggesting it might be fire or a very bright light source. The overall mood is somber and dramatic.

CHILDREN
· OF ·
PAIN

RANA ABDULLAH

Children of Pain

A Novel About Love, Loss, and Becoming

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The wound is the place where the Light enters you.

— *Rumi*

You cannot protect yourself from sadness without protecting
yourself from happiness.

— *Jonathan Safran Foer*

We are all children of pain. The question is not whether we will
suffer. The question is what we will make of it.

I

Part One - Monochrome

In Which We Meet a Man Who Has Confused Safety With Living

Chapter 1 - Museum White

There is a specific quality to the light in Manchester at half past nine on a February morning, when the sky cannot decide between grey and pearl and the pavements carry the smell of last night's rain still drying against cold stone. I have walked these streets for years without truly noticing them. This is the first real thing I learned: we spend enormous portions of our lives moving through beauty we have pre-decided is ordinary.

My name is Tariq Khan. I am the second son of a man who drove buses for thirty years and a woman who made the best haleem in Levenshulme and asked, every Sunday without variation, when I was going to get a proper job. I grew up between two worlds in the way of most British Pakistani men of my generation — fluent in both and fully at home in neither, which can be a kind of freedom if you know how to hold it, and a kind of homelessness if you don't. For a long time, I held it wrong. I was twenty-nine when this story begins, living alone in a first-floor flat on Wilmslow Road, and the story — like most stories worth telling — begins somewhere in the middle, on a Tuesday in February, in the hour I finally stopped mistaking routine for wisdom.

The café was called Amber, and it occupied the ground floor of a narrow Victorian terrace on a stretch of Wilmslow Road where the restaurants of the Curry Mile gave way to independent coffee shops and a bicycle repair place that always seemed to be closed. The café was everything its neighbours were

not: still, dim, smelling of ground coffee and cardamom and the particular warmth of a space that has absorbed years of other people's conversations. The owner was a man called Fouad, Lebanese, in his mid-forties, with the unhurried manner of someone who has decided what matters and is quietly implementing it. He had worked the same hours for eleven years. He knew my order by my third visit and never once asked me to confirm it. On bad weeks, he brought a small glass of orange juice alongside the espresso, without being asked and without explanation, as though the juice had simply appeared. I never understood how he knew the difference between my weeks. I never asked.

I came to Amber every morning ostensibly to work, walking the fifteen minutes from my flat with my eyes on the pavement in the particular posture of a person managing the world's inputs rather than receiving them. I was very good at managing. I had spent six years perfecting it. My flat was on the first floor of a Victorian terrace that had been converted sometime in the nineties and had since settled into a comfortable state of mild dilapidation. The two flats below me belonged to a retired secondary school teacher named Mr Patel, who played Indian classical music on weekend mornings — the kind of sustained, patient raga that seems to be working something out — and a young couple, recently moved from London, who argued with great energy and brief duration like summer thunderstorms. Above me, nobody. The flat above mine had been empty for two years. I found the emptiness restful.

I was a concept artist, or trying to become one. A concept artist makes worlds that do not exist. What I made were technically proficient reproductions of the gestures of world-making — correct anatomies, calibrated perspectives, competently rendered light sources — without any world actually inside them. Architecture without habitation is only a shell. I had studied the architecture and forgotten to put anything inside it. I had a drawing tablet that had cost more than my first month's rent and a stylus worn down to a nub and a second stylus in the drawer I had been reluctant to open, as though replacing the old one would constitute an acknowledgement that the work it had produced was gone and would not be retrieved. I

had reference folders organised by category — anatomy, texture, lighting, environment, costume — each containing hundreds of images, each annotated with technical observations. In my organisation of resources, I was exemplary. In my use of them, I was producing technically proficient emptiness at a consistent rate.

My portfolio existed and received, in response to every application I sent, a silence so consistent it had begun to feel like a statement. I told myself this was the industry's problem, which was sometimes true and sometimes a comfortable lie. Between rejections, I took small commissions — character designs for indie developers, website illustrations, the occasional piece for a tabletop game supplement. It paid the rent. It paid for the espresso and the water, and nothing I would call a future.

On this particular Tuesday, I had been sitting for nearly three hours and produced four gesture drawings. I immediately turned face down. The espresso had gone cold. Fouad, without being asked and without meeting my eyes, brought a fresh one and removed the old cup and departed. I sat with the fresh espresso cooling in front of me and stared at the condensation on my water glass, which was doing something genuinely beautiful in the morning light — a slow migration of droplets down the curve of the glass that caught the amber light from the pendant lamp above and fractured it into small improbable rainbows on the table surface. I did not draw it. I watched it and thought about drawing it, but did not draw it, which was a reasonable summary of my life at that point.

The door opened. The city came in before she did: a gust of February carrying diesel and something floral, a perfume that might have been rose or might have been a memory of rose — the kind of distinction that eventually stops mattering.

I looked up. And then I kept looking, longer than I had planned.

She was tall, in her early thirties, with the kind of pale skin that goes pink in cold air. Her coat was dark green — the colour of old pines, of forests that have decided to stay. Her hair, long and extraordinarily thick and dark — dyed almost certainly, a richness that the February light made look deliberate — had been caught by the wind and blown partly across her face. She pushed

it back with one hand as she crossed the threshold, and that was the moment I saw her clearly. One side of her face was burned. The scar began below her left cheekbone and spread outwards along her jaw, across her neck, disappearing beneath her collar. The skin there was the colour of pale amber, slightly drawn in the way of old burn tissue, with a surface that caught the café's low light differently — not shinier, but differently textured, as though that portion of her existed in a subtly altered atmosphere, as though light had made a separate arrangement with it.

I looked, and then I looked away. I was not proud of either movement. There is a kind of looking that is really a flinching — a quick inventory followed by an overcorrected departure of the gaze, designed to communicate that you have not looked, when the speed of the departure is itself a confession. I performed this looking, and she saw me perform it, and something in her expression adjusted — not hurt, not irritated, just a small recalibration, the way you adjust your grip on something when you realise you had initially held it wrong.

She ordered a flat white. Fouad took her order without altering his expression. She scanned the room with the quick professional efficiency of someone assessing a situation rather than simply looking for a seat. Eight other people; all tables occupied except the one across from mine. She came and sat across from me.

I returned to my sketchbook, pretending to work on one of the turned-face-down drawings. I could feel her watching me with a quality of attention different from the casual observation of someone sharing a small space — the attention of someone who had already decided something and was now simply waiting to see if events would confirm the decision.

"I've only ever attracted playboys," she said.

I set my pencil down.

"My entire life," she added. "Only playboys."

"I'm not sure what I'm supposed to do with that," I said.

"Nothing. I'm just telling you." She did not look away. "You were staring at my face."

"I was looking at my sketchbook."

“Before that.”

“Yes,” I said. She had removed every polite exit with three words. “Before that, yes.”

She nodded once, as though I had confirmed an experiment. Her flat white arrived, and she held the cup with both hands, the way people hold warm things when the warmth is not really about temperature. “The funny thing is it doesn’t stop them,” she said. “My face. If anything, it interests them. For about three months.”

“And then?”

“And then they discover that interesting is not the same thing as comfortable, and they leave.” She said this without bitterness, which was the most disturbing version of the statement possible. Bitterness at least implies the wound still registers. What she expressed was something further along: a truth processed so thoroughly it no longer generated weather.

“That’s —” I started and didn’t know how to finish. “That’s a very organised way to describe it.”

She looked at me with something that was almost amusement. “I’ve had time to organise it.”

We talked for an hour. She told me about a man she had loved for four years who had eventually asked her to become his second wife — he was Moroccan-British, she explained, a practising Muslim, and the request had been made with genuine belief in its reasonableness, which in some ways made it worse. She had refused with the quiet absoluteness of a person who knows precisely which lines constitute themselves. She did not perform the refusal for me; she reported it the way you report the weather. “He was a good man in most ways,” she said. “That’s what people don’t understand. The ones who hurt you most are rarely the simply bad ones — the simply bad ones you can leave without ambivalence. It’s the complicated ones, the good man who does the wrong thing — those are the ones you carry.” I thought about this. Outside, the February morning was doing its unremarkable thing: a woman in a hijab pushing a pram past the window, a delivery driver double-parked and unhurried, the ordinary Friday traffic of a road that feeds half the city. “Do you think he knew he was asking too much?” I said. She considered this

for a moment — a real consideration, not a rhetorical pause. “I think he knew, and he hoped I wouldn’t see it that way. There’s a difference between those two things.” “Yes,” I said. “There is.”

Her phone buzzed. She stood, gathered her coat, and leaned close enough that I caught her perfume — rose underneath something warmer, cedar perhaps, something that stayed after she had moved — and said softly: “This is between you and me. I don’t know why I told you. I don’t usually tell people things.” She straightened. “I’ll see you again. Don’t get a girlfriend in the meantime.” She was gone before I could respond. The door swung shut. The February air settled back to the ordinary temperature of a Tuesday morning, and I sat with my cold espresso and a feeling I had not had in years: the feeling of having been genuinely seen by someone, and of having, perhaps, genuinely seen them in return.

I turned to a fresh page and drew her from memory. The angle of her jaw. The way the scar caught the amber light differently from the rest of her face — not as a wound but as a feature, like the particular tilt of an eyebrow or the specific curve of a lip. The quality of her eyes, which were not soft — she was not a soft person — but which were, unmistakably, alive. I drew for twenty minutes without lifting the pencil. The drawing that emerged was the best thing I had produced in two years. I stared at it for a long time, and then at the blank espresso cup, and then at the window and the street beyond, where the Tuesday morning was continuing in its Tuesday morning way, entirely indifferent to the fact that something had shifted in me. On the walk home, for the first time in years, I looked up at the sky and noticed that it was beautiful.



I did not see her again for a month. I returned to Amber every morning, telling myself I was not waiting for her, which was the kind of lie you tell yourself when the truth is too embarrassing to carry openly. I was waiting for her. But something useful happened in the waiting: I began to actually work. The figures I drew were no longer purely mechanical. I found myself lingering on expressions, on the microgeography of feeling in a face — the way grief settles in the region between the eyebrows, the thing that happens

to a mouth just before it decides to speak or decides not to. I was drawing what I had seen in her face across that table: the specifically honest quality of a person who has stopped pretending. Fouad noticed. He said nothing — that was not his manner — but one morning, he paused behind me long enough to glance at what I was working on and then placed my espresso down with slightly more care than usual, as though he did not want to disturb whatever was happening.

I made a piece: a man on a broken surface, one arm raised towards a sphere of pale light that hung just above his reach, his face turned not in defeat but in honest acknowledgement of effort. Pain in every line of him, and also something the pain had not erased — a stubborn animal continuance, the body refusing the easier option. I posted it online. By morning, it had generated more response than anything I had made in two years. People wrote from cities I had never been to: *this is exactly how I feel, and I didn't know it could look like this*. I read every message three times. Each one felt like a hand extended through a screen.



I was in the park on a Wednesday in early March, sitting on a bench near the eastern wall, attempting to draw a plane tree whose bark was doing something complicated in the post-rain light, when I heard the old man before I saw him.

The park occupied a long rectangle between Wilmslow Road and the residential streets to the north. It had been there, in various configurations, for over a hundred years. At its centre was a stone drinking fountain — dry in summer, running in winter — around which the park organised itself with the quiet authority of something that has decided it will outlast everything around it. In the mornings, elderly men gathered near the bowling green. In the afternoons, mothers brought small children to the fountain. In the evenings, couples walked in the particular absorbed way of people who have been together long enough to have worn their companionship smooth. I had been coming here for years to draw — it was the best place in this part of the city for figure work — and I knew it the way you know a place you have never truly paid attention to: by routine rather than by seeing.

He was painting on the paving stones near the central fountain, cross-legged beside a large sheet of paper, making slow and deliberate marks with a brush worn down to a fraction of its original length. His hands shook with the particular tremor of age, but his mark-making was completely steady — the steadiness not of a body without tremor but of a will that has learned to work through the tremor rather than despite it. The painting was of a woman. Enormous, detailed, astonishing — the kind of face that requires not just technical skill but genuine love for the subject, extended over so long a time that it has become knowledge. The colours were wrong by conventional theory — too warm, too insistent on a golden quality that afternoon light in a Manchester park in early March does not produce — but they were right in the way that mattered: they communicated the truth of the subject rather than the facts of the observation.

I sat beside him without deciding to and watched him work for fifteen minutes without speaking. His eyes, when they moved from the painting to the palette and back, were the red of someone who had been outside in the wind for a long time, or of a grief so old it had become a permanent feature of the face. Possibly both. He stopped, set the brush down, and looked at me. “Are you all right, son?” “Yes,” I said — the habitual answer — and then, because he was looking at me with the same quality of direct attention she had used in the café: “I don’t know.” He nodded. “Who is she?” “I haven’t said anything about a person.” “No. But you’re watching someone paint a portrait of a dead woman with the eyes of a person who has recently seen a face that matters.” He looked back at his painting. “Who is she?” I asked. “My wife,” he said. “She died in childbirth. Forty-one years ago.” He said it without theatrical weight; it was simply the most important fact of his life, stated plainly. “I still paint her because the painting is how I continue the conversation.” “After forty-one years?” “Conversation doesn’t require the other person to be alive. It requires attention. I still have attention to give.”

He set down the brush and took my right hand, turning it over, examining the calluses from years of pencil work, the graphite smudges that never completely washed away. “Artist’s hands,” he said. “But the hands alone are not enough. Discover something that frightens you. Draw from that. The fear

is information about where the real things are.” He released my hand. It began to rain — the fine, silvery Manchester kind that feels less like precipitation and more like the air having second thoughts. I ran for the café, but slowly. I let the rain land on my face. I thought about a man who had been painting his dead wife for forty-one years with shaking hands, and about how the paintings were so alive they stopped a stranger in a park. I did not understand it yet as anything more than an interesting observation. Within a year, I would understand it as the central fact of my existence.

I went back to the park that afternoon, and I was on a bench near the central path when I heard it: rhythmic footsteps on the wet gravel, the slightly laboured breathing of someone who runs for their mind rather than their body. She was exercising. Moving through the park with complete disregard for other people’s perceptions — not defiance, which still requires an audience, but genuine indifference, which is much harder and much more powerful. She wore a dark blue running jacket, and her hair was pulled back in a way that made her scar entirely visible, framed by nothing, presented to the March afternoon with the same indifference she presented to everything. Our eyes met. She stopped.

A moment passed — the kind that is not a pause in a conversation but a separate event, a held breath between two people recognising something they are not yet sure how to name. Then she walked towards me.

Chapter 2 - The Muffled City

She sat beside me with the ease of someone for whom the question of whether she had been invited is simply not a relevant category of inquiry. She looked at my sketchbook without asking, the way people who are genuinely interested in things look at things without requiring permission first. “The tree looks sad,” she said. “Trees don’t —” “This one does. Look at how it’s holding itself.” She touched the page, not quite making contact, indicating the bend in the upper branches. “Like it’s bracing. Like it knows something is coming.” I looked at the drawing and then at the tree. She was right. I had drawn what I felt, which was not what the tree was doing but was, perhaps, more honest than what the tree was doing.

“You’re the artist from the café,” she said. “You’re the woman from the café.” “Nour,” she said. “My name is Nour.” Nour means light in Arabic. She had the name from her mother, she told me later — a Lebanese woman who had come to Manchester in the early nineties, married an Englishman from Stockport, and died when Nour was eleven. The name was one of the only things she kept without ambivalence: her mother’s language, her mother’s naming, carried into the life her mother had not lived to see. At the time, I simply thought: a name that suits her, which is not always the case.

She turned through the pages of my sketchbook with the focused attention of a careful reader, pausing at things, moving on, returning. She stopped for a long time on the reaching-man sketch — the original study from which I had

made the posted piece. She studied it with the expression I would come to recognise as her deep-attention expression: slightly still, the line between her brows barely visible, her lips not quite pressed together. "I know this one," she said. "Someone shared it. I didn't know it was you." She looked from the sketch to me. "You made this after we talked." "Yes." "I knew the orb was a person. Whoever it was made for, I knew immediately it wasn't abstract." She handed the sketchbook back. "Will you sketch me?" "I don't usually work from live sitters." "Why not?" "Because people move. Because they change what they're doing with their face when they know they're being drawn. The awareness of being watched changes what's there to be drawn." She thought about this with genuine seriousness. "That's interesting. But I don't think it applies to me. I've been looked at very specifically, with a great deal of attention, my entire life. I'm not sure I know how to change my face for being watched." She said this plainly, without pity for herself, as a simple fact about what extensive visibility does to a person. It strips away the performance of being looked at, because the performance becomes unsustainable. What you are left with, if you are strong enough, is simply yourself.

"Next time," I said. "Give me a way to reach you." She took my phone, typed a number and handed it back. She stood, brushing wet gravel from her leggings. "Don't disappear," she said, and ran. I watched her go until she was past the line of plane trees. My phone buzzed before I reached the park gate. *OK, when can we meet?* No question mark. The meeting was not being proposed; it was being announced.



We texted for a week before we met. I had conversations by text and phone regularly — with my sister Amara, who called every Sunday from Edinburgh where she had gone for a PhD and stayed for a man she married before my parents had finished protesting the distance; with my mother, who sent voice messages of variable length containing news about relatives I had not seen in years and a rotating roster of enquiries about whether I was eating properly and when I intended to get a real job and, increasingly, when I intended to get married. I was accustomed to functional communication, to conversations that served a purpose and stopped when the purpose was served.

Nour's texts were not functional. They were a way of thinking that happened to involve another person. She texted the way she spoke — directly, without the decorative language most people use to soften the edges of what they mean. When she found something funny, she said so, with the specific detail that made the thing actually funny. When she disagreed, she said so. "You're an accountant," I texted once. "How does an accountant develop this relationship with language?" "Numbers are very honest," she wrote back. "They don't perform. I think spending all day with honest things makes you less patient with dishonest ones." "Do the numbers ever lie?" "Yes. But they lie in ways you can find. That's the difference. When a number lies to you, you can go back and find the exact moment it went wrong. People are harder."

She told me about her ex-husband in pieces, over several evenings. She had been married for four years to a man she had loved genuinely and who had loved her genuinely, and the marriage had ended not because of cruelty or deception but because of incompatibility at the level of need — he needed a biological child, she could not provide one, and his need was larger than his love. That is not a moral failure. It is a genuine incompatibility, and those are not the same as moral failures even when they feel like them. "He wasn't a bad man," she said one evening. "He was good. He loved me. And the thing he could not do — stay — was not about love. It was about a different kind of need that turned out to be stronger." "Does understanding that help?" A pause. "Yes and no. It helps me be accurate. But accurate and healed aren't the same thing." Another pause, longer. "I used to want people to say he was bad. It would have been simpler. He wasn't." "What do you do with that?" "Mostly I just live with it," she said. "I don't have a better answer. I've looked for one."

She told me she had cyclothymia. She delivered this information with the same flat specificity she brought to every significant disclosure: not hiding it, not making a production of it, simply placing it in the conversation where it belonged. "What does it feel like when it's bad?" I asked. "Like the city after heavy snow," she said. "Everything the same shape, but the sound is different — muffled, reduced. Colours look like they've been photographed in low light. You know the world is there, but you can't quite access the evidence for

it. And the worst part is not the low feeling itself but knowing it will lift and you will feel foolish for having believed it while it was there.” Then she said, “Don’t try to fix it when it comes. Most people do. They need you to be all right because your not-being-all-right makes them anxious. I’m not solvable. I just need someone who can stay in the room.” “I can do that,” I said. A long pause. “Most people say that.” “I know.” “You sound very sure.” “I’m not,” I said. “But I want to be the person who can. That’s nothing.” She didn’t reply for several minutes. I put the phone down and washed the dishes, and came back, and it was still showing the typing indicator — three dots appearing and disappearing, which meant she was writing something and then deleting it, writing it again. This was not her usual pattern. Finally: “No. I suppose it isn’t.”



We met properly for the first time outside Amber on an evening in late March that had not decided what season it was. She had texted that afternoon: “I’m walking tonight. You can come if you like.” No question mark, as usual. I had been at the drawing tablet for seven hours producing nothing I would keep, and I said yes before I had thought about whether I wanted to.

She was waiting outside on the pavement in her green coat, looking up the road the way she looked at sketchbooks — with assessment, not impatience. We walked south along Wilmslow Road and then east, through streets I had walked a hundred times without truly going anywhere. She did not make conversation the way most people do: filling the air to prevent the silence from saying something. She let silence stand, and then spoke when she had something to say, which gave her words a different weight. We talked about the work — she had seen more of my pieces online than I had realised, and she had thoughts about them that were not complimentary in the way I was accustomed to. She said the technically accomplished ones were the least interesting. I told her that was not what the clients required. She said clients required what they were offered.

The rain began somewhere near the junction with Dickenson Road — the fine, vertical Manchester kind, more mist than rain, the kind that doesn’t prompt you to run but simply arrives and settles. We kept walking. She didn’t

put her hood up. I noticed this. There was something in the decision — not bravado, not indifference — but a specific peace with the conditions of the world as they actually were. She had made her accommodation with things that could not be controlled and found it comfortable. I had spent six years making mine and found it isolating. I was only beginning to understand the difference.

We stopped at a kebab shop on a corner, not because we had planned to, but because the light from it fell warmly into the wet street, and we were standing in it without having noticed we had stopped. The man behind the counter was arguing with someone on the phone in Turkish, gesturing with the hand that wasn't holding the receiver, and a small child — his daughter, perhaps, from the manner of her — was sitting on the counter eating chips and watching him with the complete equanimity of someone for whom this is simply what evenings are. Nour laughed. It was the first time I had heard her laugh properly — not the dry, contained sound she made when something was faintly amusing, but an actual laugh, the involuntary kind that arrives before you can organise yourself around it. She laughed at the child's expression, which was completely serene, and which was exactly the right thing to laugh at. I did not know what to do with the sound. I did not try to do anything with it.

We walked back through the park along the western path, where the plane trees made a corridor above us, and the lamplight came through the branches in the broken, uneven way that light always comes through things it is required to pass through. She told me about her mother — not the story of her death, which she had mentioned before with the characteristic flat delivery, but something smaller and more specific: her mother had had a habit, when she was happy, of humming to herself without knowing she was doing it, old Lebanese songs she'd learned as a girl, and Nour had spent years after she died trying to remember the melody of one particular song that she could still feel in her body but could no longer locate with her mind. She had looked it up, searched recordings, and asked her mother's surviving relatives. She had never found it. "I think I'm more afraid of losing that than of most other things," she said. "A sound I can't recover." She was not asking for comfort.

She was making a disclosure — placing the thing in the space between us with the same directness she brought to everything — and I understood, in the way you understand things that don't quite fit into language, that she did not often say this to people. That she was saying it because something had made it possible to say.

At the park gate, she stopped. The rain had thickened slightly, the fine kind becoming something more definite. "Thank you for the walk," she said, though she was the one who had proposed it. Something in this formality — the small, careful courtesy of it — was more intimate than anything direct would have been. I watched her go until the green coat disappeared between the streetlamps. Then I stood in the rain for a moment longer than was necessary and tried to identify what had changed. I could not name it precisely. But I knew, in the way you know things before you understand them, that she was not an interruption in the life I had been living. She was a rearrangement of it. These are not the same thing. The interruption passes, and life resumes. The rearrangement is permanent, whether or not the person who made it stays.



She came to my flat on a Thursday in April without warning. I had been at my drawing tablet for six hours on a commission that was paying adequately and producing nothing. I opened the door, and she stood in the corridor in her green coat with an expression I couldn't immediately read. "I wanted to watch anime," she said. The simplicity of this — no preamble, no apology for the unannounced arrival, no elaborate contextualisation — was a way of communicating what she could not quite say directly: she needed company. She had come to get it.

I stepped back. She came in. She moved through my flat the way she moved through the park — with purposeful familiarity, as though she had already mapped it in her mind and was now confirming the map. She looked at my walls: the reference studies pinned in overlapping layers, the gesture sketches on thin paper that had yellowed at the edges, the half-finished concept pieces with notes in the margins. She looked at my desk, which contained the drawing tablet and a topography of small objects — a bone folder, three types

of eraser, a ceramic mug holding seventeen pencils in varying states of use, a small yellow sticky note that said WHAT ARE YOU AFRAID OF in my own handwriting from some past instruction to myself that I could no longer date. She read the sticky note and did not comment on it. "You live in your work," she said. Not an accusation. An observation.

She began, with the calm efficiency of someone who finds disorder impractical, to make the flat navigable — not erasing the evidence of work, which stayed exactly where it was, but creating space to be in the room without feeling that the room was primarily a workspace that had a person in it. I made tea. When I came back, she was on the sofa with her coat off and her knees pulled to her chest in a way I hadn't seen before. Something about the posture was smaller than her usual posture — it was not the posture she wore in the world. "You okay?" I said. "Fine," she said — the word she used when she was not fine but had decided to be fine. I had not known her long enough to know this yet, but I was learning it.

She chose Death Note. We watched. I kept looking at her sideways, cataloguing the posture, the quality of her attention, the fact that she hadn't laughed once at the things she usually laughed at, the way her hands — which usually rested loosely in her lap — were held close together. "Stop looking at me like that," she said, eyes on the screen. "I'm not —" "You're doing the thing where you look and then quickly look away. I can see it." "Are you in a low?" I said. She was quiet for a moment. "I'm fine." "Nour." "I said I'm fine." Not sharply. With the specific flatness that meant the subject was closed.

I looked back at the screen. On it, someone was making a catastrophically bad decision with absolute conviction. Outside, the city made its ambient sound — a siren somewhere on the main road, a motorbike, the muffled argument from the flat below that would be finished within the hour. I could feel myself wanting to do something — offer something, name it, help — and I could feel her not wanting me to. The two feelings sat beside each other in the room.

After twenty minutes, she shifted and rested her head on my shoulder. Her hair was against my face. She smelled of rose and something warm underneath — something that was just her, underneath all the things she

put on in the morning. “I can’t forgive him,” she said. Very quietly. Not addressing me exactly, addressing the question she had been carrying. “I love him, and I can’t forgive him, and I’ve been waiting for one of those to resolve the other. They don’t. They just coexist.” I put my hand on her head. I did not tell her it would be all right — that would have been changing the subject from her pain to my discomfort with it. “You don’t have to resolve them,” I said. “You just have to hold both.” She was quiet for a moment. “I know that. I know it intellectually. It’s just harder at certain times.” “Is this one of those times?” A pause. “Yes.” “Okay,” I said, and I left it there, because she had told me what she needed, and the thing she needed was for me to leave it there. It required a specific effort, not doing something. I made the effort.

She fell asleep on my shoulder forty minutes later. I sat very still, feeling the weight of her head and the specific quality of trust that sleep represents — the one state in which a person cannot maintain any of their careful management strategies. She was trusting me with her sleeping self, which is the most honest version of a person. I was aware of it, and the awareness had a quality I want to describe accurately: it was not romantic, not yet. It was the feeling of being genuinely needed by someone who did not need easily, and of being afraid of being the wrong person for it, and of deciding to try anyway. I carried her to the bed when my shoulder had gone numb. I went back to the chair by the drawing tablet and sat in the dark with the city below me and the sticky note in my eyeline. WHAT ARE YOU AFRAID OF. I was frightened. I was also, for the first time in years, completely in the room I was actually inhabiting.

II

Part Two - Chalk and Cheese

In Which We Learn That Love Is Not a Feeling But a Practice

Chapter 3 - The Yes

In the morning, she woke and was herself immediately — no transitional grogginess, no slow reorientation. One moment asleep, the next present, her eyes open and already making assessments. She found her shoes and her coat and stood in the middle of the sorted room and looked at me with the softened expression that sleep leaves behind — the one that bypasses the careful management, before the day's arrangements have been put back into place. "I had a good time," she said, with the gravity of someone who means this more precisely than it sounds. She texted from the street: *I'll come back today. Don't disappear.*

She came back that afternoon. We watched thirty minutes of a film, and then she closed the laptop and turned to me and said, with the directness I had stopped being surprised by and started being grateful for: "I think I'm falling for you. I want to say it before it becomes something I'm hiding from you, because I don't hide things well and I don't want to start." She was not asking me to love her back. She was not making a transaction. She was making a disclosure — an act of respect, an offering of the true thing. "I'm falling for you too," I said, an understatement so large it bordered on a lie, but the version of the truth I could say without making more of the moment than it needed.

She took my face in her hands. Her thumbs were warm against my jaw. She turned my face towards hers with the deliberate gentleness of someone

who wants you to understand that this is a chosen action, not a compulsive one, and she kissed me. The kiss had nothing in it of performance. It was two people who had been paying close attention to each other for several weeks and who were now, simply, closer. When we stopped, she smiled — the full unguarded one, the one I had not seen until that moment — and in that smile, she looked like someone who had briefly forgotten to protect herself and was glad to have forgotten. “We should be a couple,” she said. The declaration rather than the proposal. “Yes,” I said. “You’re not afraid?” “Very afraid. I’m saying yes anyway.” She nodded as though this were the right answer. It was, I think, the right answer — not despite the fear but because of it.



The first months of being a couple were an education I had not signed up for and would not have missed. She came to my flat three or four evenings a week. I went to her flat on Sundays, which she had designated as a day for administrative living — cleaning, groceries, the various small maintenance a life requires — and which she conducted with the same focused efficiency she brought to everything. Her flat was on the second floor of a converted terrace two streets from mine, reached by a staircase whose tiles were original to the building. Her flat was spare in the way of spaces organised by someone who understands that objects carry weight and weight accumulates. She had a large print of a diagram of the human nervous system framed on the main wall — the kind you find in old medical textbooks, rendered in fine ink lines, beautiful in the way that accurate representations of complex things are always beautiful. She had plants, many of them, all alive and well-tended, on the windowsills and on the shelves alongside three bookshelves organised by some system I could never fully decode. I once asked her if they were in alphabetical order. She looked at me as though I had said something faintly offensive and said, “By mood.”

She told me once that she had moved four times in the eight years before we met, always choosing smaller rather than larger, always leaving things behind rather than accumulating them. “Every time I moved,” she said, “I got rid of something I thought I needed. After the third move, I started to understand that what I needed was a lot less than I thought, and what I wanted

was something different from either.” “What did you want?” “To stop having to decide what to take,” she said. I thought about this for a long time. It said something I recognised — the desire not for fewer things but for a state in which the question of possession had been resolved.



There was a particular Sunday in late April when I arrived at her flat and found her in the middle of something she had not been expecting to find herself in the middle of: a phone call with her father. I could hear it from the hallway — one-sided, clipped, the specific vocal register she used when she was performing composure. She signalled me in with a gesture, and I sat in the kitchen and made tea and heard the conversation end without ceremony, and then she came in and stood at the sink with her back to me for a long moment before she turned around. “He wants to come to Manchester,” she said. “I haven’t seen him in four years.” “What did you say?” “I said I’d think about it,” she said, and the way she said it made clear that thinking about it and allowing it were entirely separate things. I did not push. I put the tea in front of her and sat down, and we did not talk about it further, which was exactly what she needed.



She came to my parents’ house on a Saturday evening in early May, which my mother had proposed with the casual inevitability she brought to things she had decided were going to happen. “Bring her for dinner,” she had said on the phone, as though the question of whether Nour had been mentioned to her was not worth addressing. I had not mentioned Nour to her. My mother had a talent for knowing what the silences in my calls contained. I told Nour with the kind of studied neutrality that communicates the opposite of neutrality. She said, “I don’t eat a lot.” “She’ll cook for twelve,” I said. “She’ll cook for twenty-four,” Nour said, and I could not tell if this was concern or amusement. I suspected both.

My parents’ house in Levenshulme was the same house my father had bought in 1987 and which my mother had spent thirty-seven years making into something that communicated, in the specific idiom of South Asian domesticity, an absolute refusal to be anything other than a home. There

were photographs on the walls in no particular chronological order. Some plants had been alive for longer than I had. There were smells — cardamom and something underneath it, the particular warmth of a kitchen that is always slightly in use — that reached into the oldest parts of my memory and rearranged my nervous system before I had taken off my shoes. Nour stood in the hallway, and I watched her take it in with the quiet attention she brought to things she was calibrating herself against.

My mother had cooked haleem, biryani, dal, raita, and a lamb dish I had not seen since a wedding several years ago. This was love rendered as logistics: the calculation of what a person needed and the provision of it, at maximum capacity, before they had expressed the need. She greeted Nour with the warm, direct attention she brought to everyone she had decided deserved it — which was most people, in her estimation — and immediately concerned herself with whether Nour had eaten today. Nour said she had. My mother brought her tea anyway. These were not separate points. My father came in from the front room in his careful weekend shoes and sat in the chair he always sat in and looked at Nour with the quiet, appraising attention of a man who communicates primarily by the quality of his listening.

At the table, my mother asked questions that were not questions — observations framed as enquiries, designed to produce information while communicating care. She asked about Nour's work with the specific interest of someone who respects competence regardless of its field. Nour answered accurately and without performance, which my mother understood immediately and approved of in the way she approved of things, which was to give them more tea. My father ate steadily and spoke rarely. At one point, he said, without looking up from his plate: "And your parents — do they live nearby?" The question landed ordinarily and sat in the air in an extraordinary one. My mother reached for the serving dish. Nour was quiet for precisely long enough that I understood she was deciding not which answer to give but whether she could give it, and then she said, calmly: "My mother died when I was eleven. My father and I don't have much contact." My father looked up. He nodded once, with a specific gravity — not pity, something more considered than pity, the acknowledgement of a fact that has weight

and deserves to have that weight recognised. “That’s a long time to manage on your own,” he said. Nour looked at him. “Yes,” she said. “It is.”

My mother changed the subject with the practised efficiency of a woman who has spent decades reading rooms and acting on what she reads. She asked Nour if she liked Lahori biryani or Karachi style, and the conversation moved elsewhere, and the moment passed. But I had seen Nour register my father’s response — seen something in her face do a small, involuntary thing, like a door that had been expecting resistance and found none.

We walked home through the May evening, which was mild enough that we went slowly and by the longer route without agreeing to. She was quiet for the first few streets — not the closed silence, the processing one. Then she said: “Your parents look at you like you’re something that must not break.” I thought about this. “That’s accurate,” I said. “It’s exhausting sometimes.” “No,” she said, with the specific care she brought to corrections. “It isn’t. You think it is because you’ve never looked at the other way.” She did not say what the other way was. She did not need to. I did not push. I walked beside her through the warm evening and understood something that I filed away without fully examining: that she had survived a great deal that my family’s love had insulated me from, and that this was not a simple thing, and that it required more of her than I had yet understood how to account for.

Chapter 4 - The Waiting Room

We argued. I want to record this honestly because the arguments were part of it too — not background noise to the real relationship but the relationship itself working through its own knots. The worst one happened on a Friday in May, six weeks after we became a couple. It started, as these things do, with something small. She had mentioned, in passing, that her ex-husband had contacted her — a question about an old bank account they had shared. She mentioned it with the flat specificity she brought to all significant disclosures, in the same register as everything else, which meant I almost missed it.

“Wait,” I said. “He texted you?” “Yes. It was nothing.” “You didn’t say anything.” “I just said it.” “That was three days ago. You’re telling me now because I happened to ask what you were thinking about.” She set her cup down. “It wasn’t relevant.” “It’s relevant to me.” “Why? It was an administrative question about a joint account that closed two years ago. I replied. That’s it.” “That’s not —” I stopped, trying to locate what I actually meant. “It’s not about the content. It’s about the fact that you decided what was relevant before I had a chance to.”

A silence. Then: “You’re angry.” “I’m not angry.” “You’re doing the voice.” “I don’t have a voice.” “Everyone has a voice. Yours is when you try to sound very calm, and you’re not.” She looked at me steadily. “You can just say you’re angry.” “Fine. I’m angry. Or not angry exactly —” I stopped again. “I feel like

decisions are being made about what I should and shouldn't know, and I don't like it." She was quiet for a long moment. Outside, a bus moved slowly past the window in the Manchester rain — the kind of heavy, consistent rain that is not dramatic but simply factual, the city telling you it has no intention of changing. "I'm not trying to manage you," she said, more quietly than before. "I genuinely thought it wasn't worth mentioning. That's not manipulation. That's me being bad at estimating what matters to other people." "Because you've spent so long deciding on your own what matters." "Yes." Not defensive. Simply accurate. "I have. And I'm not always right about it." She picked up her cup and turned it in her hands. "I'm not going to apologise for the contact. But I can tell you things earlier. I can try." "That's all I'm asking." "I know. You could also ask me things instead of waiting for me to volunteer them." "That's fair," I said.

We sat in the slightly ruined feeling that follows an argument resolved not by winning but by finding the thing that was actually being said. But an hour later, she was still at my table with her arms crossed and turned away from me by some small angle I could not account for. "Are we all right?" I said. "Yes," she said, with the specific quality of a door that has been closed but not locked. I did not know whether to knock again or leave it. I left it. She left without us returning to it — kissed me briefly at the door and was gone — and I stood in the flat that still smelled of her coffee and did not know, for a while, whether what had passed between us was a clearing or a bruise. In the end, I decided it was probably both, which relationships are allowed to be.



She was impatient with my tendency to catastrophise — to extrapolate the worst possible interpretation of every ambiguous event. I was impatient with her opacity: the habit of delivering significant information in the same register as ordinary information. "You say important things like you're reading from a grocery list," I told her once. "And you treat everything as a potential crisis," she said, "which means actual crises don't get the correct level of response." A pause. She turned her cup in her hands. "I know I do it. It's not that I don't see how it lands. I just — if I make things small, they're easier to say. If I say them the right size, sometimes I can't say them at all."

“And for me it’s the opposite,” I said. “If I make things the correct size, they feel manageable. If I minimise them, they feel like they’re waiting to ambush me.” “So we’re both protecting ourselves,” she said. “Just differently.” “Yes.” She looked at me. “That’s the most annoying thing you’ve ever said.” “Because it’s true.” “Yes. Because it’s true.” She looked away, deciding something. “I’ll try to say things at the right size. If you’ll try to let some things stay small.” “Deal,” I said. We did not keep this deal perfectly. But we kept it more than we didn’t.



She told me her father’s story in pieces, slowly, testing the structural integrity of the trust before she added each new weight. She had been a child in a home where love and violence were so thoroughly intermixed that she could not, for a long time, distinguish between them. Her father was white British — Mancunian, from Gorton — a man whose tenderness and rages had come from the same source, which is to say from a place he had never been able to examine. Her mother had loved him and been afraid of him and eventually, when Nour was nine, had taken Nour and left, and then died two years later of an illness she had probably been ignoring for longer than she should have, because illness, like fear, was one more thing that had to be managed quietly. Her father had found them after the separation. He had been in the flat. He had not been violent that particular evening — it was more complicated than that, she told me, the way all the worst things are — but there had been a fire. An accident is the word that appears in the record, and she does not dispute the word or endorse it. She was nine years old. The scar was the record of that evening.

This is the inheritance of a violent childhood: not the violence itself, which the body metabolises and leaves behind, but the map. The map that tells you what love looks like, what safety feels like. The map is wrong, drawn by someone who did not know better, and the tragedy is that you use it for years before you understand it is wrong, and longer still before you can redraw it. She was, by the time I knew her, in the process of redrawing the map. She knew it was wrong. She could identify its errors with the clinical precision of someone who has done a great deal of work on herself. What she could not

do, yet, was stop consulting it by reflex. I watched her consult it and watched her catch herself consulting it and watched the particular exhaustion that followed the catching — the effort of choosing the right direction when the reflex is towards the wrong one. This is what recovery from difficult early experience looks like from the outside: not dramatic, not linear. It looks like someone is working very hard at something that appears to be standing still.

The most harmful thing I could have done was decide that love was sufficient to redraw another person's internal architecture. Only the person themselves can do this work. The most useful thing another person can do is be present and trustworthy and consistent and patient — to demonstrate by daily action that the map is wrong, so that the person can compare the map to the territory and make their own corrections. I was consistent. I was present. This was the only thing I had to offer, and I gave it.

I want to be honest about something else: I was also, during these months, becoming someone I liked more than I had previously liked myself. Not because of her directly — not because she improved me as a project — but because being in a genuine relationship with another person, in the full complexity and friction of it, was producing something in me that the managed distance never had. I was more alive. The work was better. The two things were not separate.



She suggested I introduce darkness into my work. We had been talking about a commission I was struggling with — technically accomplished, emotionally inert — when she said, without preamble: “You’re always in the moment of maximum action. You draw the confrontation, the fall, the reaching. You skip the before.” “What do you mean?” “The waiting room of a thing,” she said. “The time when you know what’s coming but it hasn’t come yet. That’s the most human time — in the space between knowing and having, between fear and the arrival of what they feared. I’ve spent a great deal of time in that space. It has a specific texture.” “What does it look like?” I asked. “If you were drawing it.” “A person in a room,” she said. “Sitting still. One hand on a closed door. Light coming through a crack.”

I went home and made that piece. I worked on it for three days with very

little sleep. I got the door wrong five times before I understood that the wrongness was about the light — I had been making the crack too bright, too clearly hopeful, when the truth of the waiting room is that the light is ambiguous. It might be something coming towards you. It might be something moving away. When it was finished, I understood: this was the best piece I had ever made. Not because of the technique. Because the feeling was true. She told me to post it. I told her it wasn't finished. She told me it was finished the moment adding more would make it less honest. I posted it. The art director who had previously ignored two applications emailed me the next morning.



The mugging happened on a Wednesday with no announcement. I had gone to the park to draw from life, found a bench, and worked well for two hours — the plane tree again, but differently seen, with more of the actual complexity of the bark. I was in the kind of absorption that good work produces, which is a state of such complete attention that it borders on vulnerability, which is probably why I did not notice them until they were close. Four of them, fifteen or sixteen, making the particular social noise of young males performing for each other. They came over. One took the sketchbook from my hands. I stood. My bag was pulled. I reached. A blow landed on the side of my head — not deliberate cruelty but careless opportunism, which is in some ways worse because it isn't personal. They ran. My bag went with them. My drawing was on the ground, torn.

I lay on the park gravel and breathed. Here is what I thought about: how long I had spent protecting myself from exactly this. The social anxiety, the managed distances, the eyes-down walk from the flat to the café — these were all strategies for preventing exactly this kind of impact. The world is reaching in and doing something to me that I had not consented to. And here I was, on the ground anyway. Protection, taken far enough, becomes a different kind of damage. Several people helped me to a bench. A man retrieved my bag from behind a hedge, minus the phone. I got home. Changed. Lay down on the floor — not the sofa, the floor; the floor was where I was, and I didn't feel like being somewhere more decided.

My backup phone buzzed. Nour. *I was thinking about you. Are you all right?* I told her. She called immediately, her voice stripped of its usual measured quality — urgent and low, all the careful management bypassed. “Are you hurt?” “A little. I’m okay.” “That’s not what I asked.” “I’m on the kitchen floor,” I said. “Literally. I don’t really feel like getting up yet.” A pause. “Okay. Stay there. Tell me about the drawing.” “What?” “The one they tore. What was it?” So I told her — the plane tree, the bark, the specific lean of the older branches and how that lean communicated something about weight and endurance that I had been trying to put into human figures without quite finding the right vocabulary. She listened without comment. She didn’t say it would be all right or that I could make another one. She just listened, and when I had finished, she said: “The drawing is already in you. The paper was just the most recent version.” She stayed on the phone for two hours. At some point, I moved from the kitchen floor to the sofa. At some point after that, I got up and made tea. These were small evidences of continuing, and she acknowledged them without making anything of them, which was exactly right. She said goodnight. I lay in the dark and understood: the fear was not protecting me. It was just isolating me. I got up at four in the morning and painted for six hours. The piece was the darkest thing I had ever made. It was also the most alive.

Chapter 5 - The Small Burials

We were, by now, something I could not name adequately in English or in the private language of feeling that has no formal vocabulary: two people who had become the organising principle of each other's days without quite having agreed to it. It was not perfect. We had different operating systems, and they did not always translate. She was impatient with my tendency to catastrophise. I was impatient with her opacity. We argued about these things with the specific energy of people who are really arguing about something else — about trust, about history, about what it means to be known by another person, and whether being known is something to seek or something to survive. But we were also, in the daily texture of being together, increasingly legible to each other. I learned the difference between her silences — the productive silence of someone thinking, the comfortable silence of someone simply present, the particular quality of silence that preceded a disclosure she hadn't yet decided to make, and the flattest silence of all, the one that meant the subject was closed. I learned that she ate very little in the morning and a great deal in the evening. I learned that she slept on her right side, facing the window. I learned that she could not watch anything involving animal suffering, not even briefly, not even in films where the animals were demonstrably fine. "I know it's not rational," she said once, when I skipped past a nature documentary. "It doesn't need to be rational." "What's irrational about it?" "Most things," she

said. "Most of my feelings about animals are irrational." "That's allowed." She looked at me sideways, as though this were a surprising position. "Is it?" "Yes," I said. "Not everything has to have a reason." She was quiet for a moment. "You didn't use to think that." "No," I said. "I'm learning."



I want to be honest about a night that I have not yet mentioned, because I am trying to tell this accurately, and accuracy requires telling the unflattering version. It was a Thursday in June, a week before her father's funeral. I had received an email that afternoon from a studio I had applied to eighteen months earlier and stopped expecting to hear from — a mid-sized games company based in Shoreditch, the kind of place I had imagined myself working in when I started and stopped imagining when the applications went unanswered. They wanted to set up a call. That evening, or the following morning, their message said, whichever worked. Nour had been in a low for five days. Not the worst she'd had — she was functional, present, doing what was needed — but the city was muffled for her, the colours reduced. I had been going to her flat in the evenings, staying for an hour, making tea, watching something. Keeping the room steady. That Thursday evening, I emailed the studio back and said seven o'clock would be fine, and I did not go to her flat.

The call went for two hours. It was the best professional conversation I had had in years. I walked home in the warm June air feeling, for the first time in a long time, like a person with a future in front of them. She texted at nine: *Are you coming tonight?* I looked at the message for a moment. *Something came up with work*, I typed. *Tomorrow?* She wrote back: *Fine*. A single word. I read it and understood, on some level, what it contained — the specific flatness of someone who has been cancelled on while they are low — and I set the phone down and told myself she had said it was fine, which was not the same as it being fine, and I knew this, and I went to bed. In the morning, she was cool with me. Not icy, not accusatory — just slightly further away than usual, a fraction of a degree. I asked if she was all right. She said she was. I did not push. We did not talk about it that week. Then her father died, and the space closed under the weight of something larger, and the small failure was

absorbed into the larger grief. I told myself it had passed. It had not passed. Things like that do not pass. They go somewhere, and they wait.



She had a cat named Vitreum — old, grey, of an improbably placid temperament, with the self-possessed dignity of a creature that has concluded most things are beneath its notice but has decided to coexist peacefully anyway. He had been her ex-husband's cat before he was hers. She had kept him not sentimentally but practically — he existed, he needed care, she was the person capable of providing it. She fed him carefully and talked to him in the particular quiet voice she used only when she thought no one was listening: low and even, asking him questions he could not answer, telling him things she was working out as she said them. He was the last connection between Nour and her previous life — the last physical object that had been in both versions of her world, the before and the after. When Vitreum died, she texted me: “The *cat is dead*”.

I went to her flat. He was in a shoebox lined with one of her sweaters — grey, which had been his, she told me, in the way that certain objects become associated with certain beings. He was on the kitchen table. She was sitting with her hands flat on either side of the box, not touching it, as though she were steadying something that was in danger of moving. I sat across from her. I put my hands on the table. I did not fill the silence. After a long time, she said, “He was the last physical thing connecting me to that marriage. To the person I was then. I don't know if I'm grieving the cat or the version of myself that existed before I knew the marriage was over.” She tried to reach her ex-husband. His phone rang without an answer. I watched her try, and I felt the small cold flare of jealousy — the automatic territorial alarm that is not about the specific person but about the possibility of being insufficient — followed immediately by the larger, more important observation: she was reaching for someone who was not responding, and the muscle memory of that reaching was doing something to her face that I recognised from her descriptions of the worst times. The habit of reaching for someone who wasn't there.

We buried the cat in the small garden behind her building, in the corner

where the sun lasted longest in the afternoons. She had checked, before we went down, that there was enough sun. She was practical about it — she had a small trowel, she had chosen the spot with care — but the practical efficiency was the way she did everything; she couldn't let herself feel while she was doing it. She did not cry in the garden. She patted the earth down firmly, twice. She stood and looked at the small mound for a moment. Then she said "Thank you" — to the garden, or the cat, or whatever deserved to be thanked — and walked with me to the building entrance and said goodnight carefully, with the care of someone conserving something. I walked home slowly in the warm May night and thought about what it means to love a person who is not yet fully available — who has a prior claim on her own interior that has not yet been fully resolved, who is still in the middle of something that you arrived late to. The full version of a person is always in the middle of something.

III

Part Three - Lead and Ash

*In Which We Learn That the People We Love Are Not Ours to
Keep*

Chapter 6 - Unforgiven Earth

Her father died in June. She had not seen him in four years. The last time was at her mother's grave in Stockport — a visit she had not told me about until weeks after, in the way she told me things that had cost her: briefly, factually, without looking at me while she said it. He had asked her to forgive him. She had not answered. She had simply been there, present in the same space, for the duration of the visit. Then she had left. "Did you know he was ill?" I asked when she told me he had died. "I knew he was older," she said. "That was enough."

She came to my door on a Thursday evening with the specific composure of someone who has decided to be held together by the performance of composure itself — who has concluded that if she stops performing it, she will come apart in ways she has not prepared for. I recognised this because I had worn it myself, in different circumstances. "He's gone," she said. I stepped back. She came in. We sat. "I don't know what I feel," she said — the most honest thing she had said to me in months, because it was the one thing she had rarely admitted: not-knowing. She had always been able to locate and name the feeling with the precision of a cartographer. This not-knowing was new, and frightening, and also the truest response available to the situation. "What you feel is the correct size of this," I said. "It's made of grief and anger and possibly relief and guilt about the relief and several other things that haven't arrived yet. That's not confusion. That's just how large it is." She

reached across the table and took my hand. "I need you to come with me," she said. "To the burial. He has no family. There's no one else."

No one else. I sat with those words. She was his last surviving family — the daughter of a man who had burned her, who had taken her mother from her, who had spent years in prison while she rebuilt herself without him, without anyone. She was the last of it, still responsible for the final acknowledgement that he had existed and that his existence required marking. There was something profound about this obligation, the burial of a parent you could not forgive — something that required action before understanding, and waiting for understanding can become a reason to avoid the action forever. "Of course," I said.

The burial was on a grey Friday morning, the last day of June — the kind of day Manchester specialises in, the sky the same shade of pewter from horizon to horizon, a light rain that cannot decide whether to commit. The cemetery was on the southern edge of the city, where the urban density thins and the streets give way to older residential roads lined with semi-detached houses in red brick. Seven people at the grave. A woman from the prison's resettlement team stood a little apart with the practised quiet of someone who attends these events regularly. An elderly neighbour from his street. A young imam who conducted the service with concentrated and non-performative care. Nour stood with her hands at her sides and her face completely controlled, which I recognised as maximum effort rather than ease. I stood beside her. Our shoulders touched. I did not take her hand because she had not offered it, and I had learned the distinction between what I could offer and what she needed.

When the grave was closed, and the others had gone, we stood in the clean wet air, and she looked down at the fresh earth for a long time. "The last time I saw him," she said, "he asked me to forgive him. At my mother's grave, in April." The rain moved through the grass on the nearby plots in small waves. "I didn't answer him. I just —" She made the gesture: present, still, occupying a space. "I stayed." "That might have been the thing," I said. "I don't know if it was enough," she said. "I'll never know. He died not knowing." A long pause. "I keep thinking that the unforgiven go somewhere with it still on them. That

he died carrying the weight of what he did. And I don't know if I pity him for that or if I think he deserved it. I think I do both at the same time." "You can do both at the same time," I said. "You're not required to resolve it." "I know," she said. "I've been telling myself that for four years. It's true. It doesn't get easier." "Does it need to get easier?" She was quiet for a long moment. Then she gave me a look I had not seen from her before: the look of someone who has been shown something unexpected in themselves. "No," she said, finally. "I suppose it doesn't."

She gave me her hand at the cemetery gate. We walked back through the grey city with neither of us speaking for a long time, and the silence was a full one — not the silence of having nothing to say but the silence of having said, in the presence of the other person, the most important things. She had told me months earlier: *I just need someone who can stay in the room.* I was in the room.

Chapter 7 - The Cost of Protection

After the burial, she asked me to paint her. “Why now?” I asked. “Because I’m ready to be seen clearly,” she said. “I wasn’t before. I had things I was still holding in front of myself. Now I’ve buried the last of them.” She meant this literally and metaphorically at the same time, which was characteristic.

I set up the easel near the window where the evening light came in at an angle that made the room look like a painting itself — warm, specific, generous to skin tones. I mixed colours for forty minutes, which is its own process of thinking: the slow discovery of what a face actually contains. The specific proportions of warm to cool, the way evening light reads differently on old scarring than on undamaged skin — not as damage, but as a different surface, with its own logic of light and shadow. She sat on the sofa and was still. She did not perform stillness — she simply went quiet, in the way she went quiet when she was in the presence of something that required her full attention. I painted for four hours.

At some point in the second hour, I stopped thinking about technique, and the painting proceeded from somewhere below thought. This happens, occasionally, when you have practised something long enough that the technical apparatus has become automatic — when the skill has moved from the front of the brain, where it was learned with deliberate concentration, to the part that operates without narration. What remains, when the technique

is automatic, is the feeling. The feeling was: I am looking at a person I have been looking at for six months, and I am still learning what I am looking at. The painting was of her as I knew her, not as I had first seen her. The scar was present — it is part of her face, part of the surface through which her interior communicates with the world, and to paint her without it would be to lie — but it was not the subject. The subject was the expression: the set of her mouth when she was listening carefully, the line between her brows when she was deciding, the quality of her eyes that I had come to understand as the expression of a person who knows the cost of continuing and has decided to continue anyway.

She stood in front of it for a long time. “That’s me,” she said. “Yes.” “Not the way I look. The way I am.” “Those have become the same thing, in you,” I said. “I’ve been looking at you for six months. They’ve become the same.” She put her head on my shoulder, and we stood in front of the painting, and the evening light moved through its slow progression towards dark. It was one of those moments a person can sometimes identify, in real time, as a moment they will carry — not because it is dramatic but because it is complete, because nothing is missing from it. “Post it,” she said. “It’s of you.” “I know. That’s why.”



I want to be honest about what happened in August. I was offered an artist residency — a month in a city I had dreamed about, a coastal city in the south of France where the light has a quality I had studied in paintings and never seen in person. I had applied without expecting anything, and the offer arrived on a Tuesday morning like something from a parallel life. I did not tell her immediately. I told myself this was because I needed time to think, which was true. I told myself the reason for the silence had nothing to do with her, which was not entirely true. The truth was that she had been in a low for three weeks — not the worst she’d had, but real and sustained — and the residency was a month, and I had been staying close and keeping the room steady, and I turned it down without telling her it had been offered. I wrote the email declining it on a Wednesday afternoon while she was at work. I deleted the acceptance email. I told myself I had made a reasonable

decision, which was also true.

Six weeks later, in September, she found out. She had met the woman who ran the programme at an event — the kind of coincidence that cities produce, the unexpected collision of separate circles — and the woman had said how sorry she was that the residency hadn't worked out, and Nour had smiled and said nothing and come home and sat across from me and said: "Tell me about the residency." I told her. She was quiet for a very long time. Outside, the city made its evening sounds. Mr Patel had started his evening music — the same patient raga, working something out. "You decided for me," she said. "I decided for both of us." "That's the same thing." She was not angry. She was something worse than angry: she was accurate. "You decided on what I could handle. You decided I wasn't well enough for you to go." "You were in a low." "I'm always going to be in a low sometimes. That's the condition. You knew this." She looked at me with an expression I had not seen before: disappointed, which is the expression that contains the most history of prior belief. "I told you: I'm not solvable. Don't try to fix it. You promised."

Then she said, with the same even voice, as though it were the next item on a list: "There was a night in June." I knew which night. "You said something came up with work," she said. "It did. I got a call from a studio. It was a real opportunity." "I'm not saying you shouldn't have taken the call," she said. "I'm saying you should have told me. Instead of 'something came up with work.'" "You said it was fine." "Of course I did. I was in a low, and I'd been waiting for you, and you cancelled with a text that told me nothing. What was I going to say?" I didn't answer. "You've done this twice now," she said. "Both times, kindly. Both times, deciding what I should and shouldn't know. I need you to understand that the kindness doesn't change the shape of the thing."

She did not leave that evening. But something shifted — the same small recalibration she had made in the café on the day we met when I looked and looked away. She was adjusting her grip on something. "Don't do that again," she said eventually. Either thing. She didn't specify. She didn't need to. "I won't." "I need you to mean that." "I know," I said. "I mean it." She nodded. Once. The conversation was closed.

But it was not forgotten. I knew this about her: she processed things

completely and did not revisit them, but she carried the weight of the processing in her understanding of the person who had required it. I had made myself, twice over, a person who had managed her. That was now part of the account. Good intentions are not absolution. The decision to protect someone, made without their consent, is a violation of the terms under which they trust you. She had asked for one thing: to be treated as a person who could survive her own experience. I had given her the opposite, and wrapped it in care, and expected it to be received as love. It was not love. It was fear of loss masquerading as love. She forgave me. She did not pretend it hadn't happened.

IV

Part Four - Negative Space

In Which We Learn What Pain Is Actually For

Chapter 8 - The Tidy Room

There was a Saturday in late October, three weeks before she died, that I have returned to more often than any other day we shared. Not because anything happened in it. Because nothing happened in it, which was, I understand now, precisely the point.

She had texted on Friday evening to ask if I wanted to come to hers on Saturday and cook. Not go out, not a plan — just the domestic, quiet version of being together that we had arrived at over the months, the kind of day that requires no organisation because it has no ambition beyond itself. I said yes. I brought bread and lemons and a bunch of the flat-leafed parsley she preferred because it tasted of something, she said, which was true. She was in the kitchen when I arrived, already doing something methodical with onions, her back to the door, Radio 4 at low volume. She heard me come in and did not turn around. “Lemons?” she said. “Lemons,” I confirmed. This was enough.

We cooked together in the particular way of people who have learned each other’s rhythms: without coordinating, without collision. She had a way of using an absolute kitchen — every action purposeful, no motion wasted — and I had learned to occupy the spaces she left rather than the spaces I might have preferred. We did not talk much. The radio filled the silence with something about interest rates. At one point, she handed me a wooden spoon without looking up, and I took it and knew what was required without being

told. This, too, was a kind of fluency.

After we ate, she washed up, which she always did immediately, and I dried, which I always did slowly, and we moved through the small rituals of the afternoon. She watered her plants one by one, with attention, as though each required its own consideration. I watched her move the watering can from the windowsill to the shelf to the kitchen and back, and there was something in the slowness of it — a deliberateness that was slightly different from her usual efficiency — that I noticed without being able to name. She was not slow by nature. Everything she did had a forward intention. This had a quality more like finishing. Like someone who is completing something they want to have completed properly.

She stood at the window for a while after, looking out at the street below, which was doing its ordinary Saturday thing — a woman with a buggy, a man walking a dog that had stopped to investigate something in the gutter with enormous seriousness, two teenagers on the opposite pavement conducting an argument that appeared to be about nothing and was probably about everything. She had the expression I associated with her deep-attention mode, but she was looking at nothing specific. She was looking at it all. “Do you think people leave marks on rooms?” she said. I was at the table behind her, sketching something in the small notebook I always carried, and I did not look up. “In what sense?” “Just — whether being in a place changes it. Whether something stays after you leave.” “I think rooms hold things for a while,” I said. “The way a coat holds warmth.” She was quiet. “Yes,” she said, after a moment. “That’s what I think too.” She turned away from the window. I returned to the sketch. Neither of us made anything of it.

Late in the afternoon, she sat beside me on the sofa and picked up the book she had been reading — a history of Byzantine art that she had checked out of the library three weeks ago and not yet returned — and read for an hour without speaking. I drew. The light changed as Manchester October light does, moving from pale gold to grey without passing through anything dramatic. At some point, she closed the book and did not open it again, but held it in her lap with both hands, the way she held warm cups. I looked at her face and saw the decided expression — the one I had painted — and

something else behind it that I could not read and did not ask about, because she had told me, from the beginning, that she needed someone who could stay in the room without requiring the room to explain itself. I stayed. I did not ask.

When I left, she came to the door, and we said goodbye in the easy, unelaborate way of people who expect to see each other soon. She said: "Thank you for the lemons." I said, "Thank you for the lunch." She smiled — not the full, unguarded one, but a smaller version, private, directed inwards at something I was not party to. I walked home through the October streets and drew in the notebook until late, and the drawing was of her at the window with the light failing behind her, and I thought it was one of the better things I had done, and I was right, and I did not know why the drawing felt elegiac because I did not yet know that it was.



There was a week before she died when she went quiet. Not the cyclothymia-quiet, which I had learned to recognise — the specific muffling, the slightly reduced gravity, the way she held herself when the city was snowed under inside her. This was different. She was present, she was responsive, she laughed at things. But there was a quality of attention she was not giving me. I could not name it at the time. In retrospect, I understand it as: she was completing herself. She was saying goodbye to things in her own order, and I was not yet on the list.

I noticed and said nothing. Then I noticed more and said something. "You're somewhere else," I said one evening. "I'm right here." "Nour." She set her cup down. "I'm just thinking a lot lately." "About what?" A long pause. "Everything. Things I haven't finished thinking about." She looked at me directly. "I need some time. Not from you specifically. Just — some time inside my own head." "Is this a low?" "No." "Then what —" "I don't want to talk about it right now," she said. The evenness in her voice had something underneath it that I should have recognised and didn't. "Can you just let it be for a little while?" I wanted to push. I wanted to say: *you tell me to stay in the room, but you won't tell me what room I'm in*. But I had made a promise to her after the residency, and the promise was to trust her. I saw her face, and I didn't push.

“Okay,” I said. She reached across and held my hand. She held it for a long time without speaking. I thought it was something resolving. I thought it was the thing passing. It was not resolving. It was her being with me, in the way she could be, in the time she had left. I understand this now. At the time, I felt only the weight of her hand and the specific quality of a person who is present and also, somehow, already elsewhere.

Two days later, I went to her flat in the afternoon without texting first — something she had told me not to do, which I had respected, but something that week had unsettled me enough that I went anyway. She opened the door, and for a half-second, before she arranged herself, her face did something I had never seen it do. Not sadness. Not the low. Something more absolute than either. “Tariq,” she said, with the specific patience of someone who is very far away and making the effort to come back. “I know,” I said. “I’m sorry. I just — I needed to see you.” She looked at me for a long moment. Then she stepped back and let me in.

We sat in her kitchen. She made tea she didn’t drink. I asked something about work — the most ordinary question I could find — and she answered it, and I asked another, and she answered that too, and for twenty minutes we talked about things that were not what either of us was talking about. Then I said, “I’m scared.” “Of what?” “I don’t know exactly. You. Something about you this week.” She was very still. “I’m all right, Tariq.” “Are you?” She held my gaze for a long time — long enough that I understood she had decided to say the true thing, or decided against it, and I could not tell which. “Yes,” she said, eventually. “I’m working through something. That’s all.” I wanted to believe her. I did believe her, mostly, because she had never lied to me directly. So I told myself this was the truth — that she was working through something, that it would pass. I went home. I did not feel better. “I love you,” I texted, from the street below her window. A long pause. Then: *I know. I love you too. Go home and sleep.* I went home. I did not sleep well.



She had a contradiction she could not resolve. I did not know it by that name while she was alive. I have named it since, in the long, patient process of understanding a person after they are no longer available to explain

themselves. She believed, with the conviction of someone who has arrived at a thing through genuine experience, that people deserve to be loved without conditions. The value of a person is not contingent on their capacity, their consistency, or their absence of damage. She had built this belief out of the specific rubble of her childhood, out of the years of therapy and the painful daily work of choosing the right direction when the reflex was towards the wrong one. And she also believed — this was the part she could not reconcile — that some people are a burden. That some damage, carried long enough, becomes weight that others should not be asked to bear. That is the kindest thing a person can do, sometimes, is to remove themselves from the equation.

These two beliefs were incompatible. She knew they were incompatible. She had named the incompatibility once, in passing, in a way I had not at the time understood as significant: “The thing I can’t work out,” she said, “is whether the rule applies to me. I can see that it applies to other people. I can argue for it with complete conviction when someone else is the subject. But when I try to apply it to myself, something fails.” “What fails?” I asked. “The conviction,” she said. “It just goes quiet. Like a signal dropping out.” I did not know what to do with this at the time. I do not know what I would have done differently, knowing what I know now. This is the thing about the information that grief brings: it arrives too late to be useful and too accurate to be dismissed. She could not love herself with the same clarity with which she saw everyone else’s right to be loved. This was the wound that the scar covered. This was the one she had not finished working on.



The night before she died, I dreamed about light. I want to place this carefully, because memory in grief is not reliable, and I have no interest in constructing retrospective significance. But the dream was specific: I was in Amber, at my table, and the light was wrong — amber and dense, the light of a threshold. She was sitting across from me with the expression I had painted — the decided one, and she said nothing. I understood, in the way of dreams, that the silence was completion.

I woke at six. The flat was grey. Her side of the bed was empty — she had gone home the previous evening, needing her own space. We had kissed

at the door, and she had said, with the wry private humour she reserved for tenderness: “You’re becoming indispensable. I find this inconvenient.” “I know,” I said. “I find it inconvenient, too.” She had smiled — the full unguarded one — and then she was gone.

I made coffee. I stood at the window. The street below was doing its morning work: a woman walking a greyhound in the misty air, the milkman’s float moving quietly along the pavement, the newsagent two doors down pulling up his security shutters with the purposeful clatter of a person for whom the day has already been organised. The phone rang. Unknown number. A police officer with very careful words. I stood at the window and listened, and the street continued below me, indifferent, ordinary, endlessly ongoing.



There are things I did not know when the officer called. I did not know whether she had made the decision that morning or whether it had been made earlier, in the quiet week I had let pass without pushing. I did not know whether there had been a moment, during that week — the afternoon I had gone to her flat uninvited, when she had made tea she didn’t drink — when something I said or did not say might have changed the direction of things. I have thought about this for a long time. I have not concluded. I do not think I will. I found, later, another letter in a drawer — a version, slightly different, that appeared to predate the one she left. Which meant she had been thinking about it for longer than the final week. Which meant the week was not a crisis but a completion.

I do not say this to make her death into something cleaner than it was. It was not clean. It was a decision made from inside a pain that I could see from the outside but could not enter, and I spent the first months after her death alternating between believing I should have pushed harder and knowing that pushing would have been, as she had told me, another way of deciding for her.

She had set the room in order. This is the detail I return to most often, the detail that contains the most of her: even at the end, she was tidy. The plants were watered — three days’ worth in each pot, exactly as much as they would

need. The nervous system print was straight on the wall. Vitreum's bowl was in its place, though Vitreum was long gone, because she could not bring herself to discard a thing that had been used for kindness. A library book was on the table with a bookmark in the last few pages, as though she had intended to finish it. She had not finished it. I have thought about the library book for a long time. It may have been left unfinished deliberately. It may have been an oversight. She was not a person who made many oversights. I have no way to know.

She left a letter. The envelope had my name in her handwriting: small, neat, deliberate, no unnecessary marks. I took it home and held it for an hour before I opened it.

I know that you are here with me in my final moments. I know that you will remember me, and I am asking you: not forever. Only until you can remember me without the remembering becoming a room you live in.

My time has come — not the way time comes to most people, incremental and unannounced, but in the deliberate way of someone who has been circling a decision for a very long time and has finally stopped circling. I was always going to come back here. I think I knew this when I sat down across from you in the café and said something strange and true to a stranger. When you are planning to leave, you become more capable of honesty.

You have less to protect. You can afford the truth. What I did not plan was you. You gave me a year I had not expected to have. A year in which I was a person who was loved with full attention. Seen clearly. Drawn a hundred times by someone who was trying to understand rather than to possess.

You will become a great artist. You already are, but you will become the kind who survives in the world, which requires first surviving the world. Forgive me. Not for my sake, I will be past it. But for yours.

Forgiveness is the thing you do for yourself. I have only just begun to understand this. There is a thing I have not been able to work out. I can

see that everyone deserves to be loved without conditions. I can argue for this, clearly, when other people are the subject.

When I try to apply it to myself, something fails. I do not know if this is a failure of logic or a failure of belief. I suspect it is neither. I suspect it is something older. I am not asking you to understand this. I am only asking you to know that I tried. The scar was never the wound. I hope you already know this. The wound was invisible. You found it anyway.

You stayed. That is the thing I will carry wherever I go.

I love you.

Don't waste the pain.

I read it four times. Then I folded it and put it in the drawer where I keep the things that need to be near me but not visible. I did not sleep. I sat at the easel with the finished portrait still on it, and I looked at the painting — the decided expression, the ongoing one, the face of a person who knows the cost of continuing and has decided to continue anyway — and I thought about how the painting had been true and how there were things it had not known how to show. The expression was the one she wore when she was with me. I had painted what she gave me to see. What I had not yet had the skill or the access to paint was what she wore when she was alone, when the careful management strategies and the directness and the specific architecture of her survival were somewhere else. That painting does not exist. I think about it. *Don't waste the pain.* I stayed at the easel until the light changed.

Chapter 9 - Grief, Honestly

Grief is not linear, not progressive, and does not end. What changes is not the grief but your relationship to it — you become, over time, more able to carry it without it occupying every room. It moves from the foreground to a different position: there, always there, sometimes more visible than others.

The first weeks were the foreground weeks. I woke with the specific weight of her absence before I was fully awake, the body registering what the mind was still catching up to. I went to Amber because it was the place where everything began. I sat at the small table near the window. Fouad brought my espresso and set it down and said, simply, “I’m sorry,” and went back to the bar without waiting for a response, which was the kindest thing anyone did for me that week. I did not draw. I sat with my hands around the cold cup and looked at the empty table across from me and tried to remember the exact quality of the way she had sat there, on the first day, with her flat white held in both hands and her eyes doing that thing — the assessment that was also an invitation, the directness that was also its own kind of generosity. I could not draw it. Not yet.

My sister Amara called every day for the first two weeks, which she had never done before. She did not say much. She asked what I had eaten. She asked whether I had been outside. She asked whether I was sleeping. These are the questions you ask when you don’t know what to ask, but understand

that your presence is required. I answered them honestly. She received the answers. Sometimes that is all there is to do. My mother came down from Levenshulme on the second Sunday with three containers of food — biryani, dal, and the haleem she made for occasions that required the best of her — and she sat at my kitchen table and did not say anything about time healing or me being young. She ate with me, and she washed the containers, and she held my face in her two hands before she left, the way she had held it when I was a child, and she said: “She was a good girl, this one. I can see it in what she did to you.” This was the most generous and the most accurate thing anyone said to me in those weeks. It cost her something to say it — I could see the cost — and she said it anyway.

My father came a week later, on his own, which he had never done in my adult life. He sat in the armchair by the window in his coat and his careful shoes, and he did not say much. He had brought mangoes from the Pakistani grocery on Dickenson Road — the good ones, the expensive ones he usually reserved for special occasions — and he peeled and sliced them in the kitchen with the methodical care he brought to everything practical and brought them in on a plate and we ate them and did not talk about what had happened, and he left after an hour. This was love in the form that he had. I received it in the form that he gave it.

Mr Patel knocked on my door on the third evening. He stood in the corridor holding a container of food — he had made khichdi, he said, and there was too much of it. He had never knocked on my door before. He handed me the container and went back to his flat without waiting to be thanked, which was also the right thing. I ate it sitting on the kitchen floor, which was still the location I found most honest. Then I washed the container and put it outside his door.



There were things I was angry about. I want to say this honestly, because I think the anger is important, and I think it is underreported in accounts of grief that come from love. The love and the anger are not sequential — they are simultaneous, coexisting in the same space, neither resolving the other, just as she had said about her inability to forgive her father. I was angry that

she had decided without me. I was angry that she had kept the quiet week to herself. I was angry at the two letters — the preliminary one and the final one — which meant that the time of the decision was longer than I had allowed myself to think, which meant that I had been in the room with her while she was circling it, and had not seen it. I was angry about the June evening — the studio call, the single-word text, the way she had said *fine*, and I had let it be fine. Whether it mattered, in the long accounting, I don't know. I don't think the distance that opened between us ever fully closed. I carry it anyway.

I was angry that she had been right about so many things and had not been able to apply the rightness to herself. I held all of this. I did not resolve it. This is what it means to stay in the room.



She had changed me at the structural level: rewritten the operating system that determined how I moved through the world, what I noticed, what I was willing to feel. I had been, before her, a person who observed life from a careful elevation. She had consequently moved me, and the work that came from that state was the only work I had made that would outlast me. This was the terrible and precise truth of it: I owed the best of myself to the worst thing that had happened to me. Not because suffering is redemptive — it isn't, not automatically, not by itself. But because she had opened something in me that pain then poured through, and the combination produced something real. *Don't waste the pain*. I went home. I began to paint.



The large painting took three weeks. It was large — four feet high by three wide. Figures arranged around a central space, the way planets arrange themselves around a gravitational centre. The central space was lit — the most illuminated point in the painting, seeming to emit light rather than receive it. The figures around it were in various relationships to this light: reaching towards it, flinching from it, circling it without quite approaching. One figure, reaching with a combination of desire and possessiveness, represented the ex-husband — the man who had loved her genuinely and whose genuine love had been insufficient to the demands of his own incompleteness. Another, crouched and doubled — simultaneously reaching and covering his face —

was her father: the violence and the grief and the imprisonment and the asked-for forgiveness that arrived too late. Around the edges, softer and less defined, the general pressure of a world that responds to visible difference with the particular discomfort of the comfortable. And in the corner, barely visible, a smaller figure: a person who had turned away. Who had managed instead of staying. I put myself in the painting. This was the first time I had put myself in a painting. It was not comfortable. It was accurate.

At the centre: the lit space. Not a void. A space that has held a person and continues to hold the shape of them, the way a bed holds a warmth for a short time after the person has left it. The presence of someone who is no longer present. I finished it, looked at it for three days, then posted it. What happened afterwards I can describe statistically — the shares, the exhibition, the recognition. But the statistics are not the point. The point is the messages — from people in cities I had never been to, who had seen the lit space and recognised in it something they had been unable to name for something they had lost. A woman who had buried her mother. A man whose marriage had ended in the specific way that leaves the love intact and the relationship destroyed. A young person who wrote: *I didn't know absence could be this full. I didn't know you could paint the shape of someone who wasn't there.* This is what art is for: the translation of private interior experience into shared exterior form. The conversion of something that has only been suffered — wordlessly, in the solitude of a single person's interior — into something that can be recognised and inhabited and used as a language by others who are also trying to describe what they have been through. She was still working in the world through painting. She had not wasted her pain either.

V

Part Five - Chiaroscuro

In Which We Learn That Every Beginning Is Also a Return

Chapter 10 - The Forty-One Year Portrait

The morning I went back to the old man, it was late July, the city at its most relentless — the heat not a single oppressive mass but a series of heated pockets through which you moved, finding, briefly, a cool draft between buildings before it closed again. Manchester in a heatwave is a city briefly stunned by something it did not expect, the red-brick terraces radiating warmth back into streets that were built for rain. I found him in his usual place near the fountain. He was not painting. He was sitting with his hands in his lap and his eyes on the water with the quality of someone who has arrived somewhere after a long journey and is simply, finally, resting.

I sat beside him. The fountain ran. “Son,” he said. “She died,” I said. He was quiet. The fountain ran. A bird landed on the rim and departed. “What did it teach you?” he asked.

“That you cannot make real work from a life you are not actually inside,” I said. “I spent six years studying how to represent human experience and protecting myself from actually having any. She ended the protection. The work that came from the ending is the only work I’ve made that means anything.” He nodded. “And?” “And that love is not a feeling. It’s a practice. Showing up in the full complexity of another person — not the edited version, not the comfortable version, but the version that includes the history and the wounds and the things they haven’t finished processing.” “And the pain?” “I’m larger than I was,” I said. “I thought grief would make me smaller. I thought

losing something that large would be a reduction. Instead, I'm expanded. There is more of me than there was before. Not less."

He looked at me with his lively eyes. "The capacity for pain and the capacity for joy are the same. They grow together. You cannot expand one without expanding the other. The person who has protected himself from pain has also, necessarily, protected himself from everything else." "She was the same capacity," I said. "She felt everything at maximum volume. The highs and the lows. It was exhausting to be near, sometimes." I stopped. "And it was the reason she was the most alive person I've ever known." "Yes," the old man said. "That is always the relationship between those two things."

He was quiet for a moment. The city noise came and went — a distant horn, a fragment of music from someone's phone passing on the path, the sustained sound of the fountain doing its work. "I got it wrong," I said. "More than once. Near the end. I made decisions she should have been consulted on. I thought I was protecting her." He nodded slowly. "Yes. That is the most common mistake." "How do you not make it?" He picked up his brush and set it down again — a habitual movement that had become part of how he thought. "You make it less," he said. "You do not stop making it. You make it less. After forty-one years, I still make it. I still sometimes paint what I wish she had been rather than what she was. I notice it when I do. I go back and correct it." "How do you know the difference?" "The paintings that come from what I wish she had been are more beautiful," he said. "The paintings that come from what she was are more true. Truth and beauty are not the same thing. Though sometimes they become the same thing, if you practice long enough."

He reached up and held my hand briefly — his grip still strong, despite the tremor — and then released it. "Make beautiful things with all of it," he said. "Use everything. The joy, the loss, the fear, the ordinary Tuesday mornings, the mistakes and the corrections. None of it should be wasted." I walked home slowly through the heat. The park was full — children at the fountain, the chess players at their tables beneath the plane trees, a couple on a bench sharing a phone with their shoulders touching, ordinary and endlessly alive. I stopped in the middle of the path and looked up at the sky, which was doing

something remarkable with the afternoon light — distributing it unevenly across the rooftops, concentrated here, absent there, making choices the way light always makes choices. I stood there for a long time. Then I went home and began.

Chapter 11 - The White Room

The months that followed were the most honest of my life, which made them also the most productive. I worked differently now: not manufacturing output but following the attention. I made fewer pieces. They were better. The difference between them and my previous work was not technical — I had not learned new skills — but experiential: they came from inside a life that had been genuinely lived. They contained, in their deepest nature, something that had actually happened to an actual person, which is the only quality that matters in the end.

I applied for the residency again the following year. I was accepted. I went for a month to a coastal city where the light is different, where the shadows are long and blue, and the water reflects into the streets. I drew from life, as the old man had told me to. I called Amara twice a week. I visited my parents for a weekend in October — the first time in two years I had stayed overnight, the first time I had sat at their kitchen table in Levenshulme and eaten my mother's food and been, as much as I was able, present with them in the way they deserved. My mother made haleem, and my father asked me, carefully, how the work was going, and I told him honestly, and he listened with the particular attention he gave to things he did not understand but was trying to. This was something new between us. It was something I had not had access to before. I do not know what I did differently. I think I was simply more in the room.

The exhibition happened in October, in a gallery in London. I stood in the white room surrounded by my own work and looked at it from the outside — the work you made in the dark, in the private struggle of making, suddenly visible from a distance. The large painting was at the centre. Around it, the chronological record: the reaching man from February, the waiting figure from April, the dark monochrome from the weeks after her quiet, the portrait I had made before the burial, and the smaller pieces from the coastal city. A year or more. The visible record of a person becoming someone who could make that year's work. A woman stood in front of the portrait for so long that the gallerist came over to ask if she was all right. She was. She was simply looking at the face in the painting with the recognition of someone who has encountered something true. The gallerist, to his credit, understood this and withdrew. This is what good work does when it is honest enough: it provides a mirror — not a flattering one, not a comforting one, but an accurate one — a surface in which the viewer can see something of their own experience reflected with sufficient clarity that the thing becomes nameable, and once it is nameable it becomes, to some small degree, less isolating.



I went back to Amber. In November, the cold returned to the city, and the morning light was doing its winter thing — lower, more amber, less generous than the summer version but more honest, illuminating things clearly rather than warmly. Fouad was at the bar. He brought my espresso and my glass of water without being asked, and then — departing from his usual pattern — he brought a small glass of orange juice as well, without comment. I looked at it. I looked at him. He had returned to the bar. It was a Thursday. I was, apparently, having a good week.

I opened my sketchbook. The page was blank. All possibilities, none of them foreclosed. I had spent years being afraid of the blank page, treating it as a reproach rather than an invitation. I no longer read it that way. I picked up my pencil. I thought about her words — *don't waste the pain* — and then I stopped thinking, which was itself something she had taught me: that at some point the preparation must end and the doing must begin. The work itself, when you trust it, when you have done enough living to have something real

to bring to it, knows what to do. You just have to show up.

The pencil moved. The door opened. The city came in, smelling of cold air and diesel and somewhere, improbably, the ghost of something floral — rose, or the memory of rose. I kept drawing.

Chapter 12 - The Architecture of Survival

There are things I have learned from this year that I want to say plainly, without the softening of novelistic indirection, because they are true and they are useful and I was thirty years old before I understood any of them.

Presence is a skill. Not a gift, not a personality type. It is a practice that requires daily effort and produces, over time, a facility. The person who is truly present with you — who is not processing their next response while you speak, not managing their own discomfort at your disclosure — is doing something that took them years to learn.

The complicated people — the ones who carry both genuine love and genuine failure in the same hands — are harder to leave and worth attending to more carefully, because the lessons they carry are more accurate. The world is populated by people who do the best they can with the interior they were given, and the best varies enormously, and some of them will harm you while loving you, and both of these things can be true.

Grief is not a malfunction. It is the correct response to the loss of something real. The magnitude of your grief is information about the magnitude of what you had.

Good intentions are not absolutism. When you make a decision that belongs to another person — however kindly, however lovingly — you have violated something. The kindness and the violation are not separate. They are the

same action.

The work of a lifetime is not to protect yourself from the events that will hurt you. The protection is a delay, not a prevention, and in the delay, you also delay everything else. The work of a life is to become the kind of person who can be hurt and remain open — who can lose and remain generous — who can grieve and still look up at the sky.

And this, finally, is the hardest one and also the truest: the people who change us most completely are not always the ones who stay. Some of them come for a specific purpose — to open a specific door, to burn away a specific protection — and then they are gone, and the door stays open, and the work they made possible continues to be made, and in this way they continue to exist in the world.

She has been in every piece I have made since February. Not visible, not credited, not literally present. But structurally present: in the quality of attention I now bring to the people I draw, in the willingness to be moved that I now understand as a prerequisite rather than risk, in the specific decision to say the true thing rather than the manageable thing. She is in the messages I receive from people who have seen the paintings. She is in the young woman who found, in the lit space, a word for something she had been carrying wordlessly. She is with the man who learned that absence can have a shape. She is operating in the world. She did not waste her pain. Neither have I. I am still learning not to.



The last time I went to the park, in late October, the old man's place was empty. The cardboard was folded against the wall. On the paving stones where he had painted for as long as I had known this park, there was a faint ghost of colour — the residue of forty-one years of returned conversations. He was not there, and I did not look for him. Some encounters are complete. The effort to extend them is a failure to trust their completeness.

I sat on the bench. The trees were in their October state — letting go in increments, the yellow-gold that is not quite dying and not quite living. October knows something that June does not: that the most beautiful moment is sometimes not the fullness but the letting go. The chess players were at

their tables, as they always were. The children were at the fountain. The dog-walkers were doing their circuits. Fouad, I knew without looking, was at the bar on Wilmslow Road, which was two streets west and perfectly ordinary and as close to a home as any place I had known. The city was doing its city thing, and I was in it, and it was enough.

I opened my sketchbook. I drew the trees, and the fountain, and the children at the fountain, and the couple on the bench sharing the small warmth of their adjacent bodies, and the old man's empty place with its ghost of colour, and the light falling through the October canopy in the uneven way that light always falls through things it is required to pass through — changed, but still light. Interrupted and continued. Altered by its passage through something real.

This is the whole of what I have to offer. Not consolation, which would be a lie. Not a resolution, which is not available. Only this: the light continues. It passes through whatever it passes through, and it is altered by the passage, and it continues. The door opens. The city comes in. The pencil moves. I am still here, and I am still drawing, and every line contains everything that has ever made me look up.

13

Coda

You come into life like February comes:
uninvited, specific, insisting on its temperature.
I had been indoors for years.
I had learned the colour of indoor light.
I had drawn it, correctly, hundreds of times,
and called the drawings finished.

You sat across from me and told me the true thing
before you knew my name,
because you had already decided that the truth
was the only currency worth spending.
I learned from this. I am still learning from this.
The lesson does not end when the teacher leaves.
Real learning takes up residence.
It continues working after the semester ends,
after the building closes,
after the light in the windows goes dark.

The scar was never the wound.

CODA

The wound was where the light was coming from.

An old man in a park is still painting his wife.

Forty-one years, and the hands are shaking,
and the brush still finds the face.

This is what love looks like when it has moved
past its beginning: not less, but different.
Built for the long weather.

The door opens.

The city comes in.

The pencil moves.

Nothing is ordinary.

Everything is the beginning of something.

Look up.

Author's Note

This novel is a work of literary fiction drawn from the emotional memory of a personal record. The medical condition cyclothymia is real: a form of chronic mood cycling that affects approximately one in a hundred people and is frequently misunderstood or misdiagnosed. Those who live with it deserve accurate representation and compassionate understanding. If you recognise yourself or someone you love in Nour's experience of this condition, I encourage you to seek out accurate information and, where needed, professional support.

The events described herein are fictional in their specifics. The feelings are true. These are not the same thing, and they are not unrelated. Fiction is, at its best, the art of the true feeling clothed in the invented event.

The treatment of suicide in this novel reflects a belief that this subject deserves to be approached with honesty rather than with avoidance or romanticisation. Nour's death is not presented as inevitable or as a resolution; it is presented as a thing that happened, with ambiguity and grief and all the unresolvable questions that attend it. If you are struggling, please reach out to someone — a person you trust, a professional, a crisis line. The wound is visible. The people who are paying attention can see it.

If you have recognised yourself in these pages — in the anxiety, the managed distance, the years of technically accomplished emptiness, the fear of being fully present to what might hurt you — then I want to say to you directly what the novel says obliquely: the protection is costing you more than the risk. The door you are standing behind is the door to everything.

And if you have recognised yourself in her — in the scar, in the directness, in the complicated inheritance of a childhood that required you to run towards rather than away from, in the long difficult work of learning that you deserve

AUTHOR'S NOTE

to be loved without conditions — then I want to say this: the wound is visible, even when you think it isn't. The people who are paying attention can see it. Some of them will stay.

You are allowed to let them.

The light in the lit space is for you.

